

overall lifetime earnings. Especially when it comes to our long-term financial goals, we are not putting enough of our money to work for us.

Why is this the case? It definitely isn't because we aren't smart or good with money, because we darn well are. According to a study by Sofi,² women invest more than men do in education to develop their careers, earning two-thirds of all graduate degrees and half of all master's and doctorate degrees. We are on top of understanding our debt and how to repay it, paying off our student loans 10% faster than men. Fidelity Investments also shared a study³ showing that women consistently save a higher percentage of their paycheck than men do.

However, when it comes to investing, women make consistent contributions 48% less than men⁴ and are typically much more conservative investors when they do invest. Almost 70% of the money women have is in cash.⁵

Some contributing factors could be the fact women don't have all the support and education they need based on the state of today's financial industry, which is heavily male-dominated. In fact, only 17%⁶ of all financial planners are female, which implies that most financial planners may not truly understand the financial planning needs women have.

Surveys⁷ show that many women believe their gender is a key factor in how they are treated when seeking financial advice. Many women have complained they've felt talked down to, stereotyped for their age and gender, or been made to feel like they didn't know what they needed. I've heard stories of this firsthand from women in the Clever Girl Finance community and I can personally attest to this treatment myself.

I vividly remember walking into a financial planning meeting as a young 20-something who needed help understanding investing, only to have the financial planner ask me if I was married and, if I wasn't, where I had gotten my money from. This line of questioning came after I had excitedly shared my objectives and goals for the money I had been able to save.

Not only did I feel patronized, I was demotivated, and I actually left the financial planner's office completely pissed off and without investing any of my money. It sat in my savings account for a good while before I decided to teach myself how to invest and started investing my money on my own.